

Whatever the merits of the bill and the military's opinion about it, what made matters worse was that the PPP Government—with Zardari's overt backing—initially ignored the military's reservations and unreservedly welcomed the American assistance. The resulting brouhaha over the bill, played up by the media and joined in by the Opposition, managed to isolate Zardari as someone willing to compromise the country's sovereignty. The fiasco over the NRO—widely perceived as a black law whitewashing official corruption—only compounded Zardari's problems of image.

Many political pundits believe that President Zardari is slowly being isolated in a way that the only way out for him may be to step down or to accept remaining only as figure-head President. Sensing his weakness, he has attempted to patch matters up once again with opposition leader Nawaz Sharif, by offering to follow through on his long-forgotten promise of giving up the powers accumulated in the presi-

would not want to lose the public respect he has rebuilt for the military. Second, at least on the issue of the anti-militancy operation, there is complete unison of view between the military and the civilian Government. The military has often complained in the past that the political will to suffer the consequences of taking on the militants—many of them nurtured by the military itself in the war against the Soviets in Afghanistan and against India in Kashmir—was lacking. It claimed that politicians often did not have the stomach to face up to public opinion when casualties mounted or when political allies objected to action against their constituents. But even President Zardari recently told his party members that “there is no turning back... until the complete elimination of the militants”.

The army claims that the major

**SOLDIERS DETAIN
ALLEGED MILITANTS AT AN
UNDISCLOSED LOCATION**



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dent's office by his predecessor General Musharraf. It may not be enough: with the NRO gone, his opponents may move in for the kill through the recently restored independent judiciary. For his part, Sharif is finding it tricky to walk the line between playing into the hands of the establishment he distrusts on the one hand, and the desire of his own party for power on the other.

But everything is not bleak for the PPP Government. For one, no serious political observer believes the army is interested in toppling the democratic process, at least for now. The conditions for military rule simply do not exist internationally and General Ashfaq Parvez Kayani in particular

part of the operation will be over in another month-and-a-half. That is certainly what the hope is, since the bitterly cold winter will set in in the area in December, which will make military operations much more difficult, especially against an enemy more used to the terrain and climate. The army has made a number of gains so far and faced much less resistance than they were expecting but whether they can continue to hold on to the captured towns and strategic terrain in the long term still remains to be seen.

No one, however, believes the military operation alone will be enough to clear militancy from the area. All that the military operation hopes to

do is to disrupt the militant networks enough for local tribes to reassert themselves and to create the space for some sort of a political process to work. Mindsets cultivated through decades of military policy and political opportunism will take much more than one Rah-i-Nijaat to change.

But the success of the current army operation and any future reconstruction of society in the militancy-plagued areas is also dependent on a seriousness of focus. To achieve this, the Pakistani political and military elite will need to set aside their petty squabbles over power and turf. Failure born out of distraction is simply not an option for Pakistan or the world. ■